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Al Gafa

Al Gafa has fashioned a career as a skilled guitar accompanist and soloist on stage and in the studio. Highlights in his career included extended stints with Carmen McRae and Dizzy Gillespie, and studio work with artists including Paul Simon and Kai Winding.

Al was interviewed via Zoom on May 2, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Al Gafa with me today, a well known guitar player and I'd like to start out with a question: When you meet someone new and someone your age and invariably a question comes up well what did you do for your career? How do you answer that? Do you have a short answer for that?

AG: I just tell them I'm a musician. That's the first thing. And then of course they always ask well what instrument do you play and I tell them guitar, and we go from there. But it doesn't always work that smoothly. I've got to tell you a story at the beginning of this thing, if you don't mind. We invited a couple over to the house at one time and that same question came up, he said, "What do you do for a living?" And at that time I was playing the Broadway show "Annie." So I said, "I'm a musician." He said, "Oh, what instrument do you play?" I said, "Well in this show I'm playing guitar and banjo." And he said, "Oh I love the banjo." And I knew it was really going to be a long evening. Okay? So when I do answer that question I always tell them that I'm a musician and the following question is always well what instrument do you play, and it's the guitar and that's it. You know. And then if they want to take it further I take it further. I don't really talk about my career too much for the sake of talking about my career.

MR: It's such a varied thing because musicians traditionally have worn so many hats in order to make a living that it is a hard thing to explain and when you say someone played the banjo they probably immediately get this impression of you playing in a Shakey's Pizza or something you know, playing Dixieland.

AG: Yeah, I didn't mean to interrupt but you know here in the United States, well you go to Europe and you tell them you're a musician they go, "Oh, you're a musician." But here in the United States you tell them you're a musician and they say, "Well is that the way you make a living? Do you make enough money? Are you a waiter?" You know it's all other things. So there's a different concept of a musician in the United States and a musician in Europe.

MR: Did your parents have this, like a bit of worry when they saw you heading towards a

AG: If they had a worry they never voiced it. You know my mom was born in America, my father was born in Europe, and there was never a decision to become a musician. I was able to play the guitar and I got a job and I've been working ever since. So it was never like I was going to devote my life to being a musician it just happened and I just stayed with it. And I know my father was extremely proud of my career, yeah.

MR: That's nice to hear. Yeah, I listened to an interview that you did with a fella named Jake and you had said that it was a hobby, it was fun. Did it become, like in high school, people, high school people, especially guys sort of get an identity you know, quarterback or they own hot cars or something. Did that become your identity as a guitar player?

AG: No. In fact it was way in the background in high school. I studied engineering in high school and the guitar was the hobby for me. It was not something that I was really focused on. I did it and, oh I'll tell you a story though, if you don't mind all these little stories.

MR: That's why we're here.

AG: Okay. I played baseball for the high school team. And just when I made the team I started getting calls for recording sessions after school. And they would set up the recording sessions. Because I was in school they would wait for school to be out. So I had to quit the baseball team to go in the studio. And the coach kind of never forgave me and he said, "How could you quit baseball for music?" And that's — it wasn't too encouraging but I never looked back at it too much.

MR: I love that. "We can't start the session yet, Al's on his way from high school." You know this was on my list of topics because I'm fascinated by those recording sessions at the time. You had stated that in the early 60s money was being thrown around in the music business. Can you extrapolate on that a little bit?

AG: Okay yeah. First of all my recording work started — I auditioned with a, it was a doo-wop group. They had an audition with two really well known artists, Doc Pomus and Morty Shuman. They wrote many Ray Charles hits and Andy Williams. They went to play an audition and they asked me to play the audition with them. And at the audition Morty Shuman, he was the keyboard player, he asked me if I would like to do recording sessions. So I'm just — it was a hobby of mine, yeah sure, okay, what's a recording session? Let's find out what it is. So I got started in the business like that. And when I graduated high school I went into the Navy and so I actually cut that recording session thing short because I went in the service. When I got out of the service I looked them up again and they threw me right back in and that's how it started. Okay. Now I forgot the other part of your question.

MR: Those first sessions, like that first audition, did they put music in front of you? Chord

AG: At the audition it was a group auditioning for them when the music had been rehearsed and all, and so that part was done. But when we were in the studio it was mostly chord charts, yes. And I need to tell you about the — these were demos. The business at that time was that writers would write a song and then they would go in the studio and record it and make this demonstration record and then mail these demonstration records out to the various artists. We would go through the publishing company and mail it out. And the guys that I started working for was this Doc Pomus and Morty Shuman, and the rhythm section, you need to know about this because Panama Francis was the drummer, Morty played piano on most of the things, Leonard Gaskin was the bass player, another old time bass player a good bass player, Kenny Burrell was the other guitar player, King Curtis was the saxophone player. So — and oh the vocalist on most of these things was Bobby Darin. So now right, I would say within a month of these sessions starting Bobby Darin relocated to California because he had "Splish Splash" was a big hit and that was the last time we saw him except we'd see him in a movie or two but not back in the demo studios anymore. So that was the rhythm section and those things didn't go through the union and every morning you'd go to the mailbox and there'd be another check for another date or something like that. It was quite lucrative at the time. And at that time you were in the studios to record these demos and everybody was throwing money into the demo field to possibly get a hit because when the hits hit they were big money, big money results from the hits.

MR: Did the demos ever become the actual record?

AG: No, but no. But a lot of times stuff that we did on the demos was just copied and taken to be in somebody's arrangement, but it was really ours in the studio. You know we'd try stuff out in the studio and something would sound good or it wouldn't sound good and we'd change it until everybody was happy and then we did it.

MR: Did you ever find that aggravating? Like there's this other group of musicians who are now basically copying what we did and they're probably getting more money?

AG: Well yeah. I think that was just part of the whole thing. You couldn't stop it and we, if we had a stronger record than they did, we did. That was it. It was over.

MR: How did you and Kenny Burrell decide — divide the guitar parts? I'll do this, you do that, you do the — one person does the chics or whatever.

AG: Yeah. I was the chic guy I think and Kenny was the rhythm guy, yeah. That's a good way to describe it, yeah.

MR: Did ego, I'll rephrase, was ego allowed in these situations?

AG: There were egos but not in the sense that your question is saying. You do this part because I can do it better, it was never anything like that. And if I was playing something

only guy on it. And if they liked what I played okay. If they didn't like what I played try this, I'll try this. So egos would only get in the way. There were a lot of guys that had different kinds of egos. Like the drummer for Aretha Franklin, Bernard Purdie —

MR: Bernard Purdie.

AG: I don't know, do you know —

MR: Yes.

AG: So when we'd go into a studio Bernard Purdie would set up all these music stands and he'd have these signs that he used to carry around "Bernard Purdie Hit Maker" and all kinds — you know like he would just stack them up. So that was his ego showing but you know what, he backed it up with music. He was a really fine drummer. You couldn't — his ego was worth every cent of it.

MR: I imagine he would sort of butt heads with the producer on occasion, because he knew what was needed?

AG: You know that's so far back. I don't ever remember that happened but it's so far back that I'm not sure that it didn't happen. Okay?

MR: Is it safe to say that you and your other musicians needed to be musically satisfied because you played just what was required and no more?

AG: Was I musically — well I'm not sure, I might have to rephrase this question. Was I musically satisfied playing what I was playing. Is that better?

MR: Sure.

AG: The answer to that is no. Because at that time in my career I was really studying hard and practicing working on my technique, working on ideas and getting flexible on the guitar and you'd be relegated to playing chics on one and the upbeat of three or something. It was so far away from what I was practicing. But I wasn't looking for musical satisfaction, I was — no I was looking for musical satisfaction for those songs. I needed those songs, any song that I participated in needed to be played really well. And if I played it well then that's my satisfaction. It wasn't to inject something I had been practicing at home on somebody's record.

MR: That's a terrific answer. I understand what you're saying. And when you say you were practicing at that time, what did a practice session normally include for you? Did you focus on one song at a time or learning new chords?

AG: I focused on technique. I used to read out of clarinet technique books and violin technique books. The clarinet is right in the center range on the guitar, it's really, you can easily incorporate the guitar literature with clarinet literature. And so I would be working on technique. I would be working to get the cleanest technique that I could get, you know if I played a note I wanted the note to come out. I didn't want like some kind of thud in

on songs, no. I didn't work on songs. But when I first started playing I worked at — I got a job at the Playboy Club. It came through another guitar player who was leaving and it was a trio job, it was guitar, bass, and piano. The piano player was Monty Alexander and the bass player was Bob Cranshaw. And the guitar player was me. I thought I knew something about the guitar from doing all that studying and playing. But when I got in that jazz situation, those two guys used to beat me up physically — musically — every night, because they were such proficient musicians. They were just off the — I couldn't figure — I used to go home at night and figure out where they knocked me out in every tune that they knocked me out and there was a regularity there. So as for learning tunes I learned those kind of tunes through them. And I learned — I didn't learn all the different — I learned different directions to take with harmonies and changes. And that improved — I started to be able to incorporate some of the studies that I did from clarinet and violin just because I had the technique to manipulate between changes. So it was really on-the-job training but heavy on-the-job training by good trainers. That's how I began.

MR: If they called a tune one night let's say "What a Difference a Day Makes" and you didn't know it, so you went home to learn it, first of all how did you access that tune? Did you have fake books?

AG: Okay let me — I have fairly decent ears so when we're on a session and somebody plays something I can anticipate where the bass line is going. It's very important for me, the bass line is the key to the thing. And so you hear the harmony on the top, you hear the bass line on the bottom, you almost know where the next change is going to go. So I can anticipate where it's going to go and I'm ready for it. But Bob and Monty, every once in a while would change the direction and I'd be playing where I think it would go and they'd be playing where they wanted to go. So that's the kind of studying I had to go home — I didn't have to learn those tunes. And I knew tons of tunes because I used to play jobs with another guitar player and his wife who was a singer, and you know singers sing fifty tunes a night and so your repertoire builds on the past.

MR: Yes and you often learn them in different keys depending on if it's a guy or a girl.

AG: Yeah. Right. Yeah.

MR: I had an incident once and it always sticks in my mind, playing in a rock band, but the guitar player was just — played the most beautiful chords and he played something one night and I asked him what it was, what chord is that, because I play piano also. And he held up his hand, he said, "It's this." And I said, "Well that doesn't really help me, can you tell me what the notes are?" And he really couldn't. He would have to like laboriously look at each string and figure oh okay. But I don't really have a question here except that guitar seems to be an instrument that you can play a lot of hip chords and so

AG: Not to me, no. It's not really fair. Because if a piano player plays a chord I can hear all the notes in the chord. And there are certain notes when you play a chord, they're volatile, they want to move in one direction or another, so you're kind of ready, you can anticipate where they're going to go. If you're wrong, you have to make a minor adjustment to fix it. And it's not a big deal. Or on a guitar from playing a three note chord and I hear that one of these notes is not the same thing I just stop that note from ringing and it's over. And the time is — it's such a short amount of time most people wouldn't even hear — you know I could stop it in the middle of striking with my right hand so I know what to do in those situations. My ear is pretty good so I hear when a piano player plays something I immediately know.

MR: Would you say you have relative pitch?

AG: Yeah. Relative is good. Yeah. It's not perfect.

MR: Okay. But it's pretty close.

AG: It's close, yeah.

MR: Yeah. Just a little bit more about this Playboy Club gig, did you get people coming up and asking for requests and sort of play them on the spot or did you pretty much get left alone?

AG: No we got — okay so the Playboy was with Monty and Bob, there were hardly requests. Because these guys are monster musicians. You want to hear the guy play, you don't want to pigeon hole him into one little song that your daughter likes or something like that. Yeah. I don't remember requests coming in. But let me tell you what happened at this Playboy Club. After about maybe eight months or so Bob — I'm sorry Monty got a call for a job at Jilly's and that was a nightclub in Manhattan that Sinatra used to hang out in and it was a noteworthy club to be in. So Monty left and the group changed. We brought in Larry Willis on piano, Earl May on drums, and the drummer at that time was Dick Berk.

MR: Earl May played the bass?

AG: Yeah. On that job he played electric bass, left handed electric bass. And so Dick Berk was with us and then after a while Dick left and we got Al Foster came in on drums. This group was dynamite. It was too strong for that club, and I'll tell you what I mean. It was the first exposure to music that anybody walking in the club was exposed to this group. This group was so powerful that they did not want to go to any of the other rooms. They had showrooms, they had a dinner room, they had two rooms upstairs that had shows. And they had a dining room that had a trio. The group was so strong that people would just stay here. And it was worth it, it was just fun. And when we got to work over there we would be bashing from the first note to the end of the job. It was just fun. Nobody

wanted to stop playing. It was just, it was the epitome of having a good time playing music. It was just a monster.

MR: Did the management notice that you were keeping people in this one spot and like you're too good?

AG: They never said you're too good to us, but they, I'm sure they noticed that people, there was a stairway that they had to walk up to get to the elevators and the stairway was always crowded with people just stopping and listening. And then after, after they'd go, some of them would go to the shows, come down and sit at the piano bar that we were in. It worked out good for everybody.

MR: And how many nights a week did you do this?

AG: Five nights a week. Yeah. But this was during the time when I was working in the studios in the daytime like Monday through Friday, and the Playboy Club Tuesday through Saturday. So any money that I made I did not have a chance to spend it because I was working. Sometimes I'd have the guitar in my hand 12 hours, 16 hours a day, with the studio work and the stuff at night. I had no chance to spend it. It was a chance to bankroll some money at an early part in my career. It was really helpful.

MR: And were you married at the time?

AG: No.

MR: Okay. When you met your future wife, did you tell her my profession is a musician?

AG: No. I mean she knew it because she was friends with I mentioned a guitar player and a singer that I used to work with at the beginning. She was friends with them. She was babysitting for their child and that's how we started — we met, and she couldn't help herself, she fell in love and that's it. But I did not say that I'm a musician so we better watch out. I never felt that we better watch out. I felt comfortable.

MR: I like that. You felt comfortable. And I doubt that then there was a particular time when you had this realization like well I'm making a living playing the guitar.

AG: Yeah, there's a lot — we were in positions sometimes where I wasn't sure how much work was coming in or I could see the work coming to an end in a couple of weeks and would something fill in, and it always did fill in. So there was never that un-ease about not being able to make a living.

MR: Did you ever have to have quote — well you had a day gig in the studio, but did you ever have a non-music job along the way?

AG: Yeah but it happened much later. It happened after Dizzy. When I came off the road with Dizzy I got very busy in town. I started working with a lot of singers. I have — I think of myself as an accompanist and singers need to have somebody that knows how to accompany them. They don't need to have somebody drag them along playing chords

the melody of a song somewhere I'm not just playing the melody, I'm playing the lyric. It's very important. And singers seem to realize that when I'm working with them. So I began, I started working with a lot of singers in town and after a while they started dying, I mean physically dying. They were Sylvia Syms, Johnny Hartman, Sammy Davis, Susannah McCorkle, you know I mean they were passing away. And I said how am I — I'm never going to be able to fill that spot. The music was starting to change then also. Good singers were getting less and less. It's almost like today, I mean when I was busy you could name twenty singers. Now you might stop at four you know, it's just a whole different — it's a different ballgame. So the singers started dying and I said I will not be able to replace what I have. And I decided to go into the school system and I have a very strong knowledge of mathematics. It comes from my engineering high school days. I went to one of the top schools in New York State so, and it was the kind of school that you had to test to get in, so the requirements were not just ordinary. It wasn't a local school, students from all over the city would be going to this school that you had to test for. My math background was just tremendous. So I started working in the school system and they found out about my math background. And at that time there was a shortage of teachers so they would make practically anybody, even if they didn't finish their math careers, they were in the classroom. And I was there to assist them in the classroom. It was just a wonderful time in my life. I found a niche that — I went that direction because here's what I said to myself — if I get a job that's going to ask me to travel I'm going, I'm not staying. But it didn't work out that way. I felt such a connection with the work in high school, I got such a connection with the kids, such a connection with the math, such a connection with the teachers that it was like not even work again it was just fun again. So I had fun, and then I started subbing at the theaters, so during the day over there, working in the theaters a couple of nights a week, and it just kept on — yes I did have a day job, but it was something that I loved. It was really fun.

MR: I just think that's great. You found another job you loved and had music, you loved that, so you became Mr. Gafa in the school system.

AG: Yeah, no, they used to call me "Mr. Al."

MR: Oh Mr. Al, okay.

AG: That was okay with me.

MR: I like that.

AG: And let me tell you, one day I came home and, you know, they're not always great days, and something must have happened at school because I came home and complained. And my wife says, "What do you expect to have fun every day?" I said, "Yeah, okay, this is what I do."

MR: I was fascinated by, you're talking about accompaniment, because one of my questions I had here was if you accompany somewhat differently playing behind an instrumentalist, Dizzy Gillespie or Sonny Stitt, as you do a vocalist? You started, I think you may have answered it but what would be the difference?

AG: Well when you're playing with guys like Dizzy they're constantly changing directions. It's just — when you're working with singers you know they don't change directions too much. They're pretty much melody singers or they'll scat a chorus or something like that but they don't really divert from, they don't divert from the tune too much. But guys like Dizzy, you know, every note has got the possibility of going somewhere else so it's — what happens when you play with guys like that you have to play less and less because it gives you more flexibility. As soon as you hear them changing then you've got to change the voicing of the chord or a note, one note in the chord or something like that. And so with singers it's straight ahead and with jazz players you're on the edge all the time.

MR: Did you replace Mike Longo in his group?

AG: Mike was in the piano — was playing piano when I joined the group so we had a quintet at the beginning. And Mike left after about a year so I didn't really replace him. But when he left — Mike was the most difficult piano player that I ever worked with. And I can tell you musically why — because he played a lot of chords. He played chords no matter what I played he was playing what he wanted to play in the way of a chord. And there would be these constant conflicts where I'd sit on a note and he would play a note a half a step away from that note and it's just like somebody's scratching chalk on a blackboard for me, it just used to drive me up the wall. So he was the only piano player in my life that I really had trouble working with. And when he left we — Dizzy took his salary and split it up and the group opened up harmonically for me, it opened up harmonically for Dizzy. There was — nothing was locked in anymore. And you know I did another four years with Dizzy without a piano.

MR: That's really so interesting. Did you find yourself, when it was piano and guitar, did you opt at times to just like lay out?

AG: Yeah. Yeah. No I don't think I ever had to lay out but I had to really be aware of what he was playing. I still was playing with the soloist. The soloist at the time would be Dizzy. And so that was my focus. Every once in a while I'd hear Mike play something and if I think I needed to go get it, I got it. But I never opted out of playing just because Mike was playing, no.

MR: When he — when the solo focus would go to the piano did you play differently?

AG: Yeah. I played according to his solo. Whatever he was doing, he's the — you know when you're taking the solo, that's the word solo, and the rest should be an accompany, in the

MR: When the tables turned and it was a guitar solo —

AG: No.

MR: Getting down in the weeds here.

AG: You don't even have to finish the question. The answer was no.

MR: Okay. We'll let our listeners try to figure that little sequence out.

AG: Okay.

MR: I wanted to read something briefly that — I was able to do an interview with Mike and he said this about Dizzy. He was talking about spirituality and the energy in the music, and Mike said about Dizzy, "Energy was pretty much a metaphysical thing that causes the music to have a divine quality to it and Dizzy was aware of the divinity. Dizzy was a celestial being and I saw that. He was the most amazing human being I ever met in my life." How did you feel about Dizzy?

AG: Well I thought he was a genius. I mean when he played, yeah, he was definitely something not of this earth. He was in another planet when he was doing these things. He played, he was innovative and he was quick and humorous, and if he wanted me to play a chord he would play it in his solo. And if I'm listening I'm hearing it easy. It makes it easy for me. And he heard everything I played. I don't know how he did that but I'll give you an example. One night I changed a chord in an original composition, I changed one note in the chord for like a bar, maybe two bars. At the end of the set he said, "Do you want to change the chord?" I said (I'll be very frank with you) — you know what? I didn't know he was listening that close but he was. And I said, "No, I don't want to change the chord, I just wanted to try it out and see what it" — I never did that again, and you know, so he heard everything, he played everything, and he loved to play. He loved to play. And at sound checks in the afternoon before opening up we'd wind up starting a tune and then pretty soon we're playing and we're playing a couple of tunes and — because he loved to play. And he was very free with his knowledge, and it was a really astounding five years.

MR: There's a very humorous story in Bill Crow's book of *Jazz Anecdotes* about Dizzy doing a Latin number and the bass player was just supposed to play one note on a particular beat and he lost it and etcetera, it's a fairly long story, but I wondered if playing Dizzy's Latin repertoire was something new for you and was it an adjustment?

AG: It was not new and let me tell you we were playing a bunch of my tunes also. So yeah, there was no — you know Dizzy had arrangements on let's say like "One Note Samba." He had his arrangement of "One Note Samba." I didn't play my arrangement of "One Note Samba," we played his arrangement. So everything was, it was not new and you tried to be as creative as you can every night. You know you can't always do that but you

try. So no, it was not new, it was, not old hat but it used to change every night. The solos would change every night.

MR: How was he different from, as a leader, from let's say Carmen McRae?

AG: Oh I knew you were going to bring this up, because this is a really — we're talking about the sound checks in the afternoon of a new job. Any time — not any time, every time I went on a new job with Carmen she would get into an argument with the club owner or the manager on the afternoon during the sound check, about something. Maybe the lights in the dressing room were not bright, maybe the dressing room needed to be dusted or the rug needed to be vacuumed or this or this. We would start every job with tension. But once she hit the stand and started singing we were in a different atmosphere, it was over. There was none of that came — ever came to the forefront in her performances. And so when I left Carmen I got the call for Dizzy. And I'm saying to myself is this going to be more of the same? And it was absolutely 180 degrees in the opposite direction. It was beautiful. So it was fine. And I need to tell you this first job that I worked with Dizzy, this is with the quintet. It was some joint in Cleveland or something like that I think. And at the end of the first set, and I had never seen his music before, he just called me and we went out. We got on the airplane and so the music is in front and I played it. So before the second set I said to him, I said, "Do you want me to change anything that I'm doing here to help out here?" He said, "If I played the guitar I would play it like you do." So that's like, okay, that's a big relief off me, I don't have to be tiptoeing around anything. And he was just that kind of — he was inspirational, that's really inspiring for a musician — go ahead and play, you play whatever you like you know. It works.

MR: That's a terrific compliment. "If I played the guitar I'd play like you."

AG: Well I don't think — maybe he meant — maybe that has some other connotations.

MR: Okay. Did he talk about his Bahái faith much?

AG: Not — he was never preaching to us, but we were always aware that he was a Bahái, yes. And one time we went to Israel and we went to Haifa and he thought he was in heaven over there, because that's I think the center of where Bahái came from. But he never tried to inject Bahái-ism upon us. And he toed the mark pretty much to their religion, about drugs and drinking and stuff like that.

MR: Mike Longo had mentioned some racial tension when he was with the group, I think the times, the late 60s and early 70s from a social standpoint there was some things that crept into the music business, but I wondered if you ever experienced, because it was a mixed group, and any issues?

AG: Never any issues with the group. Absolutely no issues at all. He was around when my first daughter was born and he was, and so there were no racial issues in that group.

Every once in a while something would come out but it would be from a foreign entity, not the group.

MR: Glad to hear that. And what did your kids — you have one kid? One child?

AG: Two daughters, yeah.

MR: So do I.

AG: Okay.

MR: Do you — what did they think of your profession?

AG: Now they absolutely love it you know. And they were always aware that I was a guitar player. My youngest daughter had wanted to become a singer. She was a fairly decent singer. And I didn't have the — I didn't want to discourage her because this is a tough business. I'm not kidding, this is a really disgusting business sometimes. And for female singers in it it's even worse because they're — everybody promises them everything but they don't come through. And so I didn't have the — I didn't want to discourage her from becoming one and she went a year and a half to Purchase college and studied music and then the college was just too much off the New York scene for her. She loved the New York scene, she loved the cabaret scene in New York. She loved the club scene, not the cabaret scene. She loved the club scene in New York and Purchase, New York is — you know the lights go out at 8:30 I think over there. So that was not for her. She did not stay. But she came back home, I lived pretty close to a college and she enrolled in the music program at the college. And I volunteered to stop in and I did a performance with her that was absolutely — she sung "When I Fall in Love," just guitar and voice. I had tears in my eyes, I'm on the stand with just my daughter. It was beautiful. So that's a crowning part in my life. I can not replace that. That was beautiful. And my other daughter, when she got married they invited us over for dinner and she's playing all these jazz things in the background, you know, on YouTube or something. And I said, "Gee I didn't know that you liked this kind of music." She said, "Well I've been around it all my life and it's part of my life." All right. Yeah. And still today when my wife and I go there for dinner there's jazz in the background. My youngest daughter likes hip hop every once in a while but that doesn't usually last for long. Either somebody gets mad or I get mad you know, and then we take it off.

MR: You're making my face hurt, Al, from smiling so much. I've had some similar experiences and you can't beat it.

AG: Yeah.

MR: You mentioned that Dizzy included some of your compositions in his repertoire and I enjoyed some of the selections from your 1976 recording "Leblon Beach."

AG: Yeah. Thank you.

MR: How do you — how do you compose? And do you compose on purpose, like I think I'll write a song today?

AG: No. Okay, there are two ways to compose that I know. One was what you just mentioned. Doc Pomus and Morty Shuman used to spend six and eight hours a day composing. And I didn't. I would find stuff while I'm practicing or playing and then I'd start to develop it. And I'd develop it into, it would just naturally develop into a tune. So my composing thing comes from practicing and having the guitar in my hands. And the reason I started composing so much is that when I joined the group we were playing a lot of Mike's tunes and we would play them over and over and over, and I was bored playing the same tunes over and over, so I started writing. And what I started writing fit the group. When I'm in a group situation for a long time I can write for the strengths of the group, it's very easy, just 'cause I'm thinking about that group 24 hours a day. And then you think about well maybe this might work and then you develop it and it does work. All right? So I started writing a little more when I was with Dizzy. That was not the first — that was not my first experience with writing, I used to do a lot of these demo dates, I used to do a lot of demo dates for a publishing company, it was called Screen Gems/Columbia Music. And one of the producers said, "Duane Eddy is looking for material for an album." So I said to myself I could probably write something for that guy, he's like a hack guitar player. I could write that. So I didn't really say that, but I thought I could write something simple for this guy to play, and I did. My first composition that I ever presented to anybody was recorded by Duane Eddy. And it was called "Laughing Guitar." That was not my title, somebody wrote lyrics to it and it got recorded. And then when I was at the Playboy Club with Kai Winding I wrote another thing called "Dirty Dog" and Kai Winding played it. So my stuff has been recorded before Dizzy. Dizzy was just easier to write with Dizzy because we were working 200 days a year and I'm looking to always play some new stuff you know.

MR: Did you ever get, or do you ever get checks in the mail for things that you have written?

AG: Yeah. Sure. But you know what? They are royalty checks and after 30 years if you don't have a really tremendous smash they get smaller and smaller and smaller and smaller until they're not worth the paper that they're — you know, they're small right now. You can't buy a pack of cigarettes, even if you smoked you can't buy a pack of cigarettes.

MR: Yeah the checks get smaller and the prices are going up.

AG: Yeah. Yeah. Well that's right, that hits the nail right on the head. Yes — I'm sorry — yes I still get royalty checks for writing and publishing too.

MR: Well the tune that's on that Pablo record, "Barcelona" it's so listenable. It's — and when you mentioned your composing often times comes from practicing I can almost picture

how that might happen, that you're doing some technique thing on a chord and then you find yourself playing this other chord.

AG: Absolutely.

MR: Now it needs a release. And — lovely.

AG: Thank you. You know what? That happens to be my favorite composition. And I got only one bad break on it. Stan Getz wanted to record it. And Stan said, "Give me the music, I'll record it." So I gave him the music and then two months later he passed away. But I would have loved to have him record it because he had all those records with Chick Corea and this tune was — it was the both of them together. And that's what — I would have loved to have him do that. And it's been recorded by Al Haig and I think Steve Kuhn and you know, me and Dizzy. It's my favorite composition. And it was created exactly what you said before. I tune my bottom string to a D, which is like a whole tone below the standard tuning. And I always play with it like that. And I'm using the three open strings on the bottom and they're vibrating constantly on the bottom 'cause I'm striking them and then I'm changing the voicings on the top. And so this thing just started with like a D major to a D minor to an E major to a G minor, you know it's just like moving down and it just felt so good to play. And so there's a continuation of this story. When I finally got it all together, even the bridge has the same bass pattern. The bass pattern is completely the same throughout the tune except for one little vamp. But it's still the open D and A in the bottom. It's just — I hate to say it but it's a really good tune. So we were on the road, we were doing a tribute to Charlie Parker, which — with Billy Eckstine and Jay McShann and Earl Hines, you know they had their bands together. It was supposed to be a tribute to Charlie Parker but — with Billy Eckstine singing his hits was not, no longer a tribute to Charlie Parker. That was — Phil Woods was supposed to be on it but Phil left because of Billy's selection of material. He didn't want to be part of that. So in the — we're sitting in the dressing room and Dizzy and I started playing and we get to this — it's an E chord with a D in the bottom. Dizzy said, "What's that chord?" So I told him what it was and I spelled it out and he heard it. And that's the thing I think that got him interested in the tune and then we started, we rehearsed it and it became part of the repertoire.

MR: How do you write out your tunes if you want to publish them? And how much of them gets written out? Because I know sometimes guitars uses tablature, but if you wanted to write a lead sheet —

AG: Yeah you write a lead sheet with the melody and you write it with the changes above it and that's really good enough for the publishing part of it, for the Library of Congress it's good enough, yeah.

AG: No. No.

MR: I wonder why?

AG: I don't know.

MR: Gee and if they did you probably could get like, you know, a check for 25 cents or something.

AG: Yeah I think maybe you're over-estimating the amount from the fake book. Yeah. I would love to have this tune — you know what? I met a guy in Dallas one time, he said whenever there was a jam session guys would play "Barcelona." So that's pretty nice. It's a logical tune, it's a smart tune, and the changes are not — they're logical. The harmonies — it feels good to play. I'm not just saying that for myself, it just feels good to play. I would enjoy playing it even if I didn't write it.

MR: Okay. I'm looking on your list of recordings you've done with other people and it's interesting that it goes from Carmen McRae to Paul Simon and then there's an entry here about The Monkees.

AG: Uh huh. Well you know that was in my studio days, probably somewhere between '64 or '68 or something like that, and The Monkees were a hot group and they were in recording and I got a call to go in and do this — it was a demo that stayed on the album. So that's my recording scene with The Monkees. We did two or three tunes and — in a small studio, not a big studio, and they ended up on several of the albums.

MR: Interesting. Not that much different from those early demos you did.

AG: Right. Right. They were easy guys. Maybe they were easy because I don't know if any of them had any talent except maybe David, the lead singer — I can't remember his name.

MR: Davy Jones.

AG: Yeah. Yeah. Well I don't know it could be, I don't remember last names. And I think the drummer could play. The rest of them were nothing. And you know I don't remember anything memorable. If you ask me what the name of the tune was or anything like that I wouldn't know it. It was just another job you know.

MR: Just another job. That's a lot about what a music career is about, isn't it?

AG: Yeah you're probably right there, yeah. I've been lucky. Because I've been lucky to be in more permanent situations than not. You know I'm in a lot of — and when you're in a permanent situation you can really grow. Because it's there, it's going to be more of the same the next night and you can improve on what you got. Otherwise it's — if you work a job here and you don't see the same musicians for another two months it's like a whole new ballgame as opposed to — that's why I say I enjoy working with the same groups because I can write into the strengths, I can play into the strengths, and by doing both of those things you can raise the level of the group too. So let me get back to the Paul Simon

pieces in the thing. And he would go to every individual piece and listen what they were playing in, right next to you, he was standing right next to you while you're playing. So a record, or a tune that would normally take twenty minutes would take three hours because we had a vast amount of musicians. And so it was more tedious than anything. But you know what? He produced great records all the time so that was his way of getting exactly what he wanted. And he would make these little changes and you'd do it and that's it.

MR: Would he make changes in things like the horn or the string parts? He'd like walk around and listen for something?

AG: Yeah. He'd listen to everybody and suggest something or not suggest something. I can't remember who, one of the arrangers — I would be guessing — but anyway that's what he did. And his records were just marvelous records. They were just produced at a high level and you know I was there.

MR: Were most of the — was most of the band there playing together or did you do a lot of overdubbing?

AG: No together, together. I don't know what happened after we got out of the studio but the band played together.

MR: And because Paul, but Paul was a decent guitar player and —

AG: Yeah.

MR: So did you know what he was going to play? Was he playing it while you were playing? I guess my question is how did you fit your guitar playing into his strumming?

AG: No the parts were written. There was hardly any, there was nothing improvised in his music for the guitar part. I don't know, you know the players were pretty good. I'm sure that if somebody made a change that he would listen to it again to see if it was better than what he had envisioned. And you know I mean he had drummers like Steve Gadd and Grady Tate, you know if they envision something let's hear it. If it works, fine. These are monster musicians so I'll take some feedback from them any day.

MR: Have you ever been in a car and a Paul Simon tune comes on and you go, "Oh yeah, I was on that"?

AG: It didn't happen in the car but I'll tell you what the tunes that I was on were on the "Kodachrome" album. So I was at — this community that I live in they had a guy come in the other night and sing tunes and play guitar. And I turned to the woman next to me and I said, "I was on that album." So not in a car but in another situation.

MR: I love that. I love the outtro at the end of "Kodachrome" man, that thing is rockin'. There's that piano part [scats]. Who was that?

AG: I don't know. I don't know. The only guys I know were Steve Gadd and I think Cranshaw might have been on one of the dates. Richard Davis, do you know that name Richard Davis the bass player?

MR: Sure.

AG: Yeah he was on one I think. Hubert Laws. Yeah, and oh, Jerome Richardson. I'm starting to get the picture now, Jerome Richardson, maybe Joe Newman, trumpet player I think Joe was maybe with Basie at one time.

MR: Sure he was.

AG: It was good, yeah.

MR: Did you ever sit in the guitar section with Bucky Pizzarelli?

AG: Only on one date, yeah. And it was for a piano player by the name of Charles Coleman. I don't know anything about his career anymore. Charles was one of the players at the Playboy Club when I was there and he was doing this date and he had me called in for that date and Bucky was the other guitar player on it.

MR: Well going back to those clarinet etudes you were playing on guitar, your reading must have gotten pretty strong. I'm wondering if you ever found yourself in a situation with a piece of guitar music in front of you going oh my, this is like, I need to woodshed this before I can play it?

AG: Yeah, well yeah absolutely. I participated in a rehearsal band with — I think it was Adolph Sandole or Dennis Sandole, one of the guys. And they had — the music was just so difficult, I'm telling you now, in my lifetime I might not be able to play it at the speed it was to be played at. It just was physically not in my capabilities. Maybe someone else could have done it but it would have taken years for me to have that under my fingers and maybe never ever get it. But there was a trumpet player on this — when you brought this up it immediately brought this scene back to mind. The music was difficult and this trumpet player ripped through it like he had been reading it all his life. It was Bert Collins. Bert was a studio musician and also did a lot of Broadway work, but brilliant trumpet player. And I'll tell you, I was embarrassed to be that far away from where I should have been on that topic. So the studies that I did came in handy but every once in a while you'd be thrown a curve like that that you couldn't hit, or that I couldn't hit anyway.

MR: You currently have opportunities to get out and perform?

AG: I work every once in a while. I'm working with a trio, a piano player by the name of Alex Leonard, he sings and plays piano, he does both of them well — and Jay Leonhart is the bass player. So we just did a concert over here where I live, it was last week. It was the 27th of April. Normally the capacity is around 110, and they had to shut it down at 150

because in this community I'm a really good tennis player and there's like 90 families in here that play tennis, and everybody in that community knows me because I'm a good tennis player. They showed up. There's an arts group that would show up anyway whether I was here or not, and you know the word got around that they couldn't handle the volume. But so yes I do get out and play and it's usually with these three guys but every once in a while — oh I did a job at a club called the Zinc Bar in Manhattan. It was part of this guitar masters series. I did it with Jay and a piano player by the name of Ted Rosenthal. Excellent players both of them and I had to do two one-hour sets and both sets were sold out. And that's a nice feeling, to go in and have that. I didn't think I was that popular, I would have asked for more money.

MR: More royalty checks.

AG: Yeah.

MR: The guitar players who may watch this interview will say well why didn't he ask him about what guitar Al prefers? Have you had a guitar of choice throughout your career?

AG: Yeah it had to be the one that I used with Dizzy and I used it with Carmen, I used it with the Playboy Club quartet, I use it almost — it's an acoustic electric guitar. And that means it's an acoustic instrument and the pick-up is, there's no holes in the pick-up. It's suspended on the neck. So the instrument really has a really wooden sound, a warm, wooden acoustic instrument sound. And it fits with jazz, it fits the thing with Carmen, it fits countless situations. It's my go-to guitar. And if somebody calls me for a date they're usually looking for this guitar too. So that is my go to — it's a Johnny Smith Gibson. It was made I think in 1961 or '62 and I was the first owner. And I bought it — I ordered it, I didn't play it, I ordered it from a music store and hoping that it would work in the studio because I needed a good rhythm — I had a thin body Gibson that I used, ES 225, it was thin hollow but it had a not good rhythm sound that I needed sometimes. And so I bought this in the mail. And at first it was like boy the two of us are fighting all the time you know. It's not giving me what I need here. And I spent a lot of money to get it and eventually I beat it into submission and it came around and it's still — it's in my bedroom now. And when I'm on the road with anybody it's on one of the beds in the room. It's like out there. It's always there. It is my go-to.

MR: I think I read that Johnny Smith was an influence on you when you first started playing. Is that correct?

AG: Yeah it was. I loved the sound that he got, I loved the voicings that he got, and I wanted to try to figure out how to do both. The technique I could do, the voicings, my fingers were not as long as his were and not — yeah. I worked — I got one part of it but not both parts. And so I used to listen to him so much that if I bought a new album I could tell you

could just hear it you know. He was definitely an influence in that part of my career. But the other influence on me was Wes Montgomery. I used to go to, there was a club in Harlem called "Count Basie's." They used to feature guitar trios: guitar, organ and drums. And it was loaded with really good players, Wes, Kenny Burrell, Grant Green, George Benson, and a saxophone player named Eddie Harris. So I go in to listen to Wes and I'd listen from ten to two in the morning. Then I'd drive home and I'd practice another three hours or so. Because he just, he was so inspiring and he played so wonderful ideas I wanted to find out, before I forgot them I wanted to see if I could find them. And I spent many nights over there sitting on a bar stool listening and hearing this guy play. It was just fire, fire, beauty. And I think he was a more influential on my career than Johnny Smith because I kind of gravitated to the thicker sound and the triplets would come out a little different than Johnny Smith's triplets. So I loved him. And when he died it was a loss for me you know. His career had just started to change into the Creed Taylor years where it started to change. And it was not the same Wes that I was listening to but it was still really good anyway.

MR: Yeah I think some people, maybe it was Creed, saw a new avenue for him and maybe more sales.

AG: Absolutely more sales. And you know what? Wes was such a great guy that he deserved anything that he could get financially from his success. He was just — he'd see you on the street — the first time I saw him on the street I didn't even know him. I'm walking in one direction and he's walking the other way. And he says hi. So that's — I know other guys that would look at you and say what are you looking at, and that kind of thing you know. So Wes was just a magnificent person.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating hour, Al, and I appreciate your time and congratulations on your career. I find it very uplifting that you've managed to do everything that you love.

AG: I'll tell you what, I would not change one thing. Okay? Not — some things don't always go smoothly but I would not change it. It's been a really great ride and I'm going to keep it — as long as the phone is ringing I'm going to be playing.

MR: Good for you. All right, thanks a lot for your time. I'll pause and we'll say our good-byes.

AG: Great. Thank you, Monk.